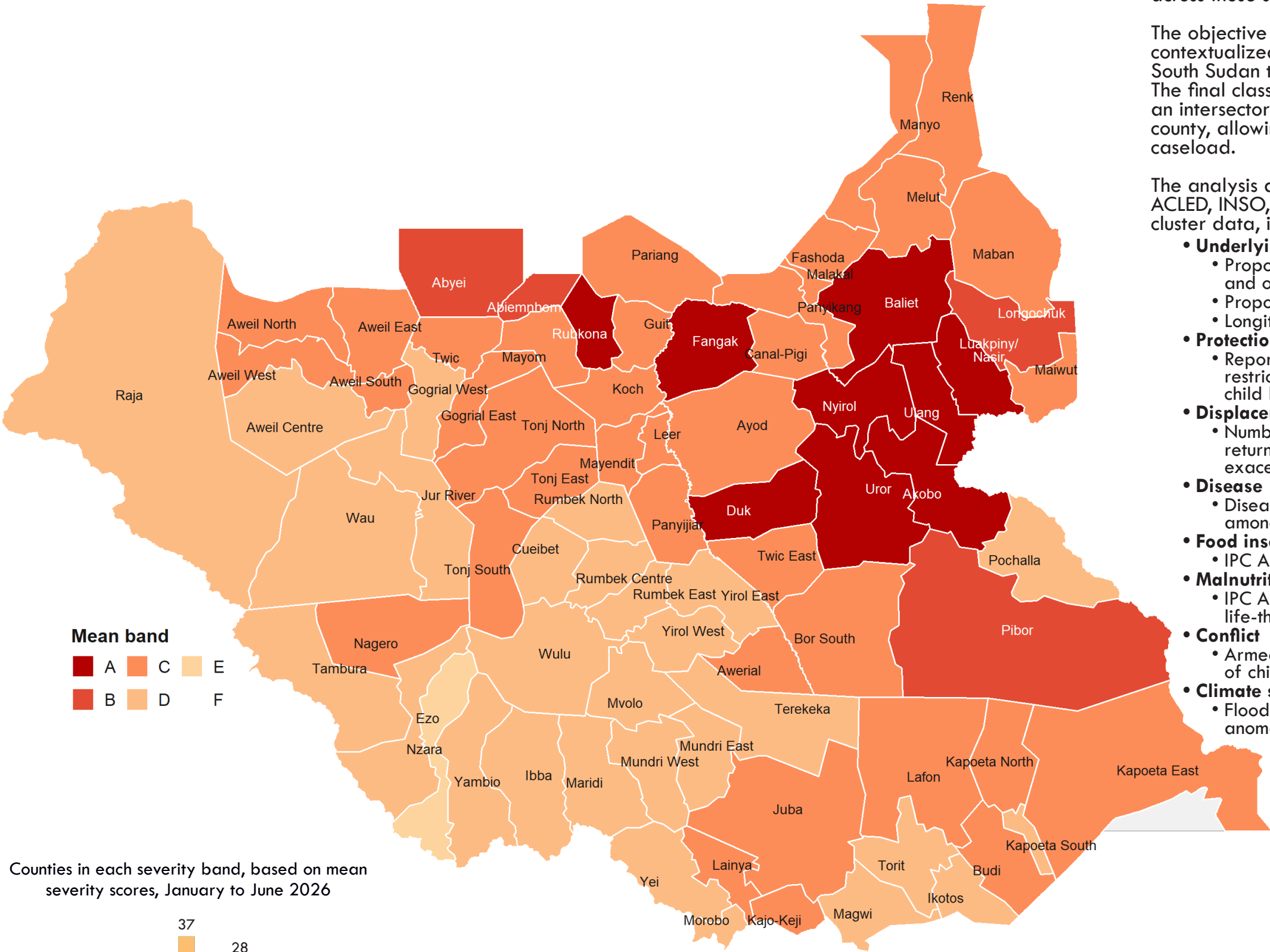


SOUTH SUDAN – NEEDS ANALYSIS WORKING GROUP (NAWG)

Trend Analysis: January to June 2026



Background

This publication covers the first six 2026 NAWG analysis cycles, from January to June. The map and band counts show mean severity by county across those six analysis cycles.

The objective of the NAWG is to conduct evidence-based and contextualized analysis of critical life-saving humanitarian needs across South Sudan to inform decision-making and prioritization by the ICCG. The final classification (from extreme to minor humanitarian needs) is an intersectoral measure of the severity of humanitarian conditions in a county, allowing comparison between counties and over time. It is not a caseload.

The analysis draws on FSNMS, ISNA, IPC AFI and AMN, SMART surveys, ACLED, INSO, IRNAs, REACH data, IOM DTM, WHO IDSR, PRMS and cluster data, informing these indicators:

- **Underlying vulnerability**
 - Proportion of female-headed households, child-headed households and other vulnerable-group headed households
 - Proportion of IDPs and/or returnees compared to host communities
 - Longitudinal food insecurity
- **Protection**
 - Reports of explosive hazards, lack of access to humanitarian assistance, restriction of movement, sexual violence, family separation, HLP issues, child labour, civil documentation issues, among others
- **Displacement**
 - Number of displaced persons arriving and/or number of returnees returning, as a significant number of arrivals has the potential to exacerbate food and resource access
- **Disease**
 - Disease outbreaks, including cholera, measles, meningitis, and malaria, among others
- **Food insecurity**
 - IPC AFI classifications are used for each county
- **Malnutrition**
 - IPC AMN classifications or SMART survey data are used as a proxy for life-threatening acute malnutrition and excess mortality risk.
- **Conflict**
 - Armed conflict events, conflict-related sexual violence, forced recruitment of children, targeted killings of civilians, targeted property destruction
- **Climate shocks**
 - Flood-related displacement, flood extent, drought stress, rainfall anomalies.

Needs severity levels

Severity band	Indicator threshold	Severity level definitions
A	8 - 10	Extreme humanitarian conditions
B	7 - 7.9	Very severe humanitarian conditions
C	6 - 6.9	Severe humanitarian conditions
D	4 - 5.9	Moderate humanitarian conditions
E	2 - 3.9	Stressed humanitarian conditions
F	0 - 1.9	Minor or acceptable humanitarian conditions

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Key messages

Severity rose and broadened across the six 2026 cycles. On a comparable scale, national severity from March onward stood above every cycle mean recorded in 2023, 2024 and 2025, while the size of the January-to-June rise was in line with previous years.

The national mean Needs Severity Score (NSS) rose from 5.98 in January to 6.33 in the June cycle. Over the same period, the number of counties classified in Band C or above increased from 46 to 57, while the number in Bands A or B increased from 15 to 18. In the June cycle, 12 counties were in Band A and ten were classified in IPC AMN Phase 5, while nine counties remained in Band A throughout all six cycles.

The persistent high-severity core remained concentrated in Jonglei, Unity and Upper Nile. At the same time, several of the largest increases were located farther west and south. Seven of the ten largest score increases occurred in Western Bahr el Ghazal and the Equatorias. The national picture should therefore be read as the coexistence of entrenched extreme severity and emerging deterioration, not as a uniform national trajectory.

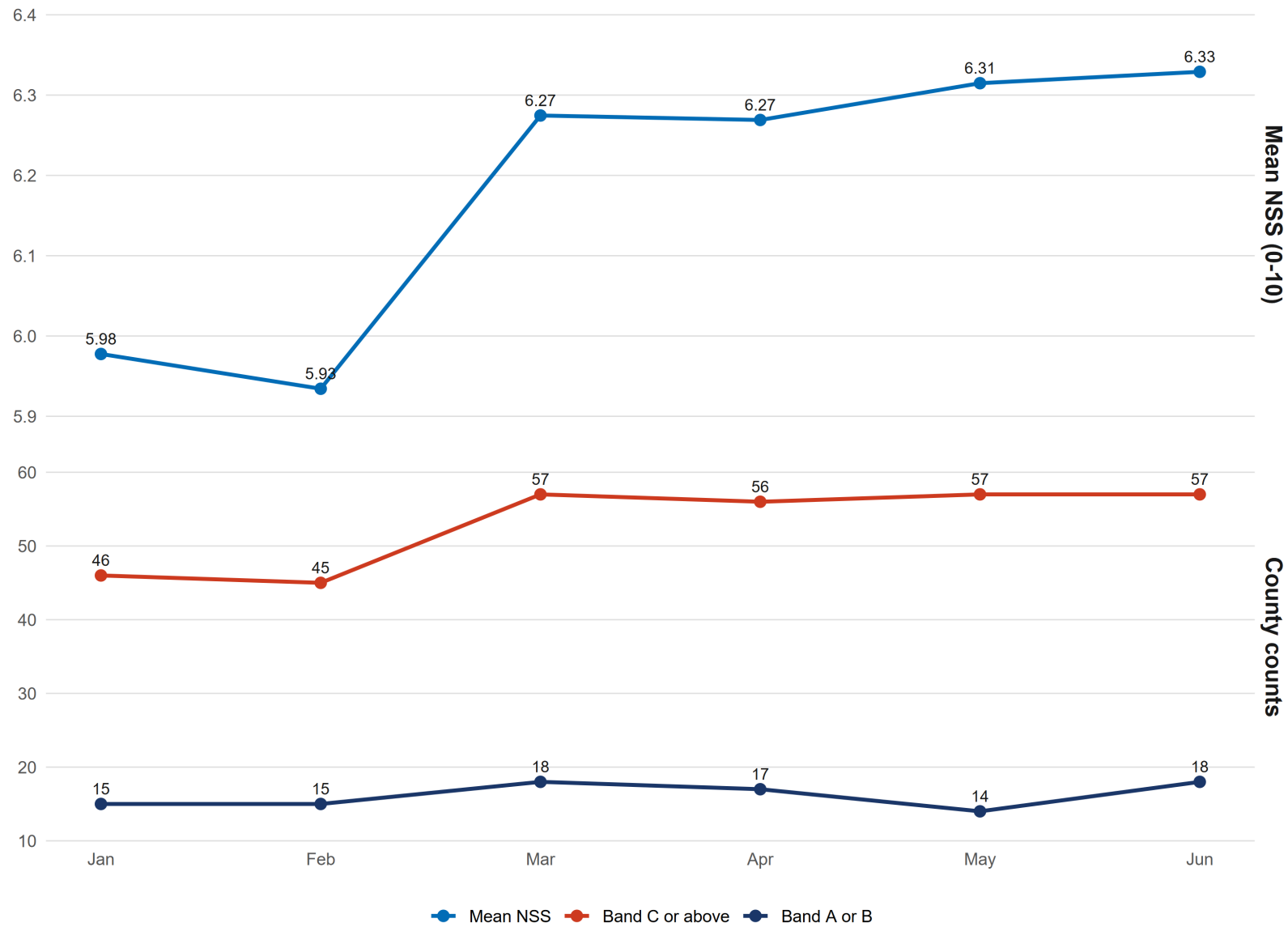
The deterioration was therefore visible both in the average score and in the breadth of severe classifications. It was not, however, a continuous cycle-to-cycle escalation. The largest shift occurred in March, when updated food security and acute malnutrition classifications entered the analysis, after which the national mean and the number of counties in Band C or above largely plateaued.

Published 2026 scores cannot be compared directly with published 2025 scores because the analytical framework changed. Re-expressed on the 2025 scale, the 2026 mean was above the published 2025 mean in all six cycles, by 0.17 to 0.55 points, and from March onward it stood above 6.49 in April 2025, the highest cycle mean in the 2023 to 2025 record. The January-to-June rise itself, about 0.29 to 0.34 points, was in line with the 0.26 to 0.44 points recorded over the same months in 2023, 2024 and 2025.

Food insecurity contributed about 0.24 points to the 0.35-point increase in the national mean, acute malnutrition about 0.11 and climate about 0.11. Lower displacement-flow pressure offset about 0.11 points, while protection and conflict provided smaller offsets. The two classification stages added about 0.06 points between them.

The final June distribution comprised 12 counties in Band A, six in Band B, 39 in Band C, 21 in Band D and one in Band E; no county was in Band F. This means nearly three quarters of the 79 county-level analytical units were in Band C or above, and 18 were in the two highest-severity bands. The final mean of 6.33 sits within Band C, but the distribution is more informative than the mean alone because it distinguishes widespread severe conditions from the smaller set of counties facing very severe or extreme conditions. The mean provides a useful summary of national direction, but it masks county transitions, score floors and offsetting pillar movements. The plateau after March does not mean that all counties were stable, and the 0.35-point rise does not imply a uniform worsening of the same magnitude across the country.

National severity, January to June 2026



National mean NSS and county counts across the six cycles in 2026, for 79 counties.

How the national trend moved

The national mean moved from 5.98 in January to 5.93 in February. The number of counties in Band C or above also fell slightly, from 46 to 45, while the combined Band A and B count remained at 15. This early movement was modest and did not establish a sustained improving trend.

The mean increased to 6.27 in March, a rise of about 0.34 points from February. The number of counties in Band C or above rose from 45 to 57, while the number in Bands A or B rose from 15 to 18. Updated IPC Acute Food Insecurity (AFI) and Acute Malnutrition (AMN) classifications were incorporated in this cycle, and the driver decomposition confirms that these two pillars accounted for most of the positive movement over the full January-to-June period.

The analysis comprises six rolling two-month cycles, labelled January to June after the first month in each data window. The January cycle covers January and February 2026, the February cycle covers February and March, and so on through the June cycle, which covers June and July. Each label therefore refers to one analysis cycle, not to two separate monthly observations.

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Trend Analysis: January to June 2026

Where severity concentrated

The geography of the highest sustained severity was different from the geography of the largest increases.

Nine counties were in Band A in every one of the six cycles: Akobo, Duk, Fangak, Nyirol and Uror in Jonglei, Baliel, Luakpiny/Nasir and Ulang in Upper Nile, and Rubkona in Unity. Their mean scores ranged from 8.00 to 8.32 and most did not move at all, because they were already at the top of the scale. Abyei was in Band A or B throughout and ended the period in Band A, and Abiemnhom and Pibor were in Band A or B in five of the six cycles.

Three counties reached the highest bands from a markedly lower starting point. Lafon rose 1.84 points from Band D to Band B, Kajo-Keji 1.40 points from Band D to Band B and Guit 1.19 points from Band C to Band A. Contextual NAWG review carried the final step in each case, adding 1.15 points in Guit, 1.00 in Lafon and 0.90 in Kajo-Keji. Five counties entered Bands A or B in the June cycle, and three of them did so through contextual review rather than through a change in the automatic score.

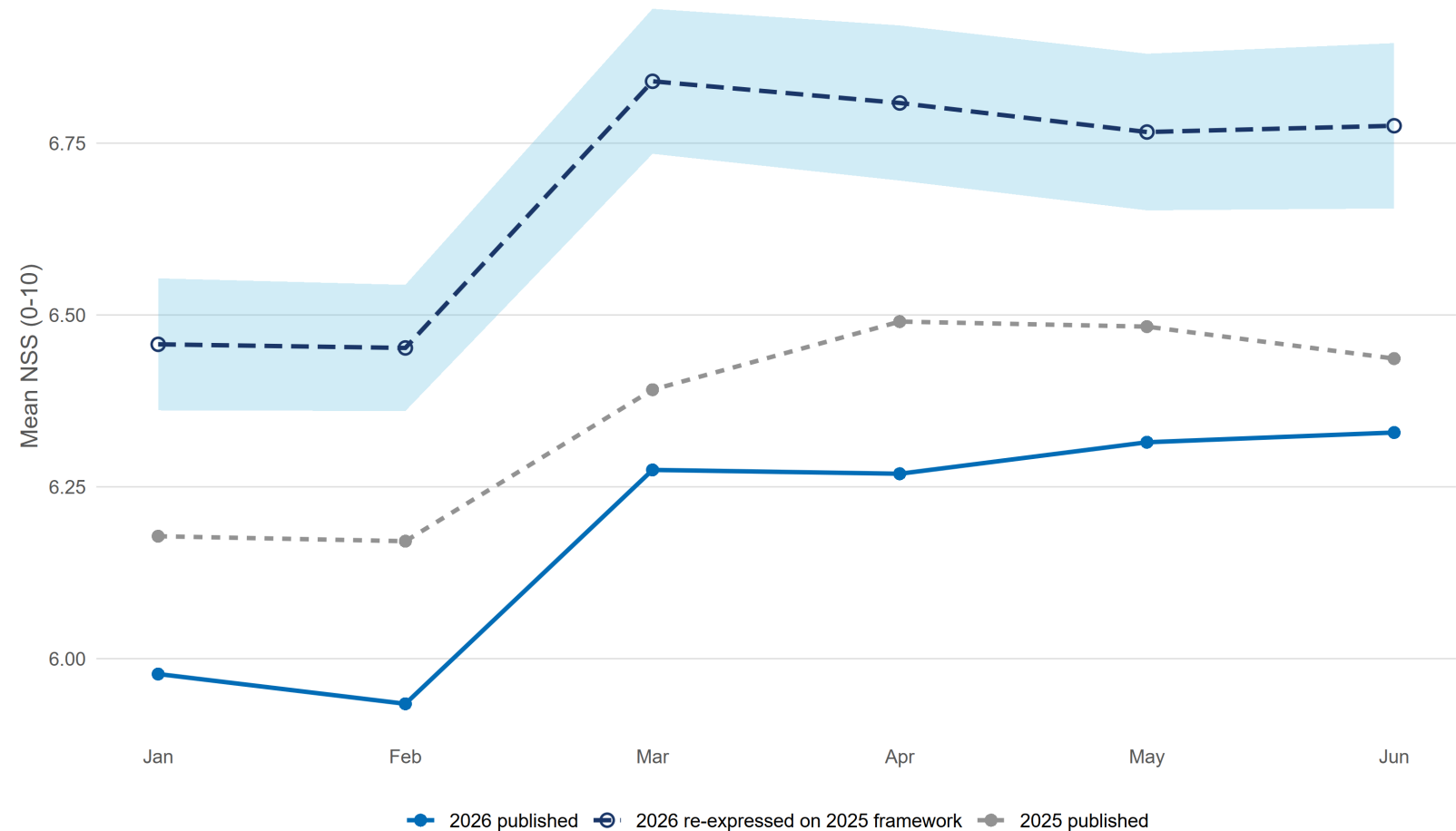
A second group recorded large increases without reaching the highest bands. Jur River rose 2.19 points, the largest movement of the period, from Band E to Band C. Ibba rose 1.38 points and Ikotos 1.37, both from Band E to Band D, Wau rose 1.38 points from Band D to Band C, and Tambura rose 1.29 points while remaining in Band D. Seven of the ten largest increases were in Western Bahr el Ghazal and the Equatorias, a different geography from the entrenched core in the northeast. Food insecurity was the largest single pillar contribution in most of these counties.

Reductions were fewer and smaller. Ayod recorded the largest fall, 0.77 points, moving from Band A to Band B, followed by Terekeka at 0.75 points, Juba at 0.61, Tonj South at 0.59 and Mayom at 0.58, with Mayom moving from Band B to Band C. Lower measured displacement-flow and protection pressure accounted for most of these movements. They are reductions in measured severity relative to the rest of the country and do not indicate that needs in those counties are low or resolved.

Persistence here means Band A or B in at least five of the six cycles, which is 83 per cent and the closest six-cycle equivalent to the 80 per cent rule used in the annual analysis. Twelve counties met it, and another 14 reached Band A or B at least once without doing so, giving 26 counties that touched the two highest bands at some point against 18 in the June cycle alone. The footprint of very severe conditions was therefore about twice the size of its persistent core. Across the full period 19 counties moved to a more severe band, three moved to a less severe band and 57 ended in the band where they started. Aweil East is the closest to a further change, at 6.73 in Band C and 0.27 points below the Band B threshold of 7.00, having risen 0.25 points in each of the last two cycles.

The same five-of-six rule sorts the rest of the distribution: 34 counties were in Band C or above in at least five cycles without reaching Band A or B often enough to be persistent, 21 were in Band D or below in at least five cycles, and the remaining 12 met none of the three tests. The annual analysis also flags a county as volatile when the standard deviation of its score reaches 0.75, which only Jur River at 1.00 and Abiemnhom at 0.79 do here.

2026 and 2025 on the same scale



Published 2026 scores, the same counties re-expressed on the 2025 scale, and published 2025 scores.

Methodology and interpretation

The 2026 analytical framework differs from the 2025 framework in pillar coverage, weights, underlying vulnerability and automatic methodological restrictions. The published 2025 and 2026 means therefore cannot be compared directly. For a like-for-like comparison, the re-scaling applies the 2025 weights and restriction logic to the 2026 inputs. Climate and conflict are excluded because they were not part of the 2025 framework, the 2026 automatic adjustment is not carried across, while the contextual review component was added once after re-scaling.

On that scale the 2026 mean Needs Severity Score is above the published 2025 mean in all six cycles and under both displacement-flow assumptions, by 0.17 to 0.55 points. In June, the re-expressed mean was 6.66 to 6.90, compared with 6.44 in June 2025. From March onward, it also exceeded 6.49 in April 2025, the highest cycle mean in the 2023–2025 record. However, the January-to-June increase of 0.29 to 0.34 points remained within the 0.26 to 0.44-point increases recorded over the same period in the preceding three years. **This indicates higher severity in 2026, but not an exceptional pace of nationwide deterioration.**

Automatic assignment of counties with AMN Phase 5 to Band A was introduced in 2026. A direct cross-year comparison of Band A counts would therefore combine a methodological change with any change in underlying conditions. The chart above therefore compares mean scores rather than Band A counts.

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Why severity rose

The national mean rose 0.35 points between January and June. About 0.29 of that came from changes in the underlying evidence, led by food insecurity and acute malnutrition, with automatic methodological restrictions adding about 0.06 and contextual review about 0.01.

The rise can be traced to individual pillars. Food insecurity contributed the most, approximately +0.242 points, with acute malnutrition adding about +0.114 and climate about +0.108. Disease added a smaller +0.016 and underlying vulnerability was unchanged at the national mean. Those increases were partly offset by displacement flow at about -0.108, protection at -0.051 and conflict at -0.035. Together the underlying evidence accounts for an increase of roughly 0.287 points, which is why the national change should not be attributed to any single sector.

Two further stages sit on top of that evidence, and they are separate from one another. Automatic methodological restrictions apply a minimum score once specified IPC thresholds are reached: AFI Phase 4 with Phase 5 pockets or AMN Phase 5 applies a minimum of Band A. Otherwise, AFI or AMN Phase 4 applies a minimum of Band C; counties below those IPC thresholds are not subject to an IPC floor. They raised 13 county scores in January and 21 in June, adding approximately 0.056 points to the national mean. Contextual NAWG review is the final stage and added approximately 0.008 points nationally, increasing five county scores in June, reducing two and leaving 72 unchanged. That small national figure understates its weight locally: the largest single review adjustment in the June cycle was 1.15 points, enough to move one county from Band C to Band A.

Almost all of the movement occurred in one step. The national mean fell 0.04 points between the January and February cycles, rose 0.34 points between February and March, and moved a further 0.05 points in total across the three cycles that followed.

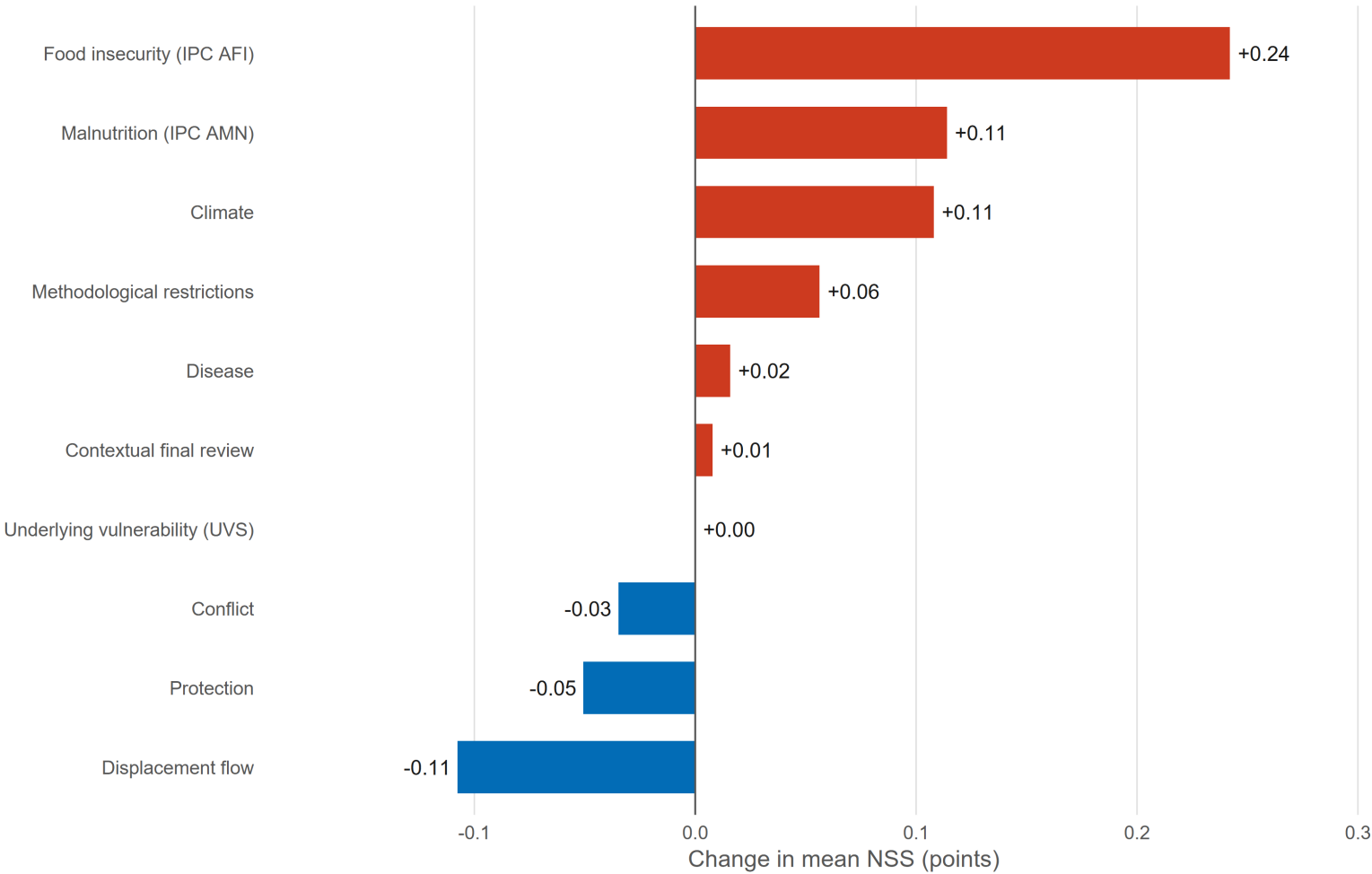
How the pillars moved

Counties classified in IPC AFI Phase 4 or worse increased from 15 in January to 36 in March and remained at 36 through June. Within the final distribution, 30 counties were in Phase 4 and six had Phase 4 classifications with Phase 5 pockets. The increase in the severe AFI categories explains much of the March rise and contributed approximately 0.24 points to the national mean over the full period.

Counties in IPC AMN Phase 4 or worse increased from 38 in January to 48 in March and remained at that level. AMN Phase 5 counties doubled from five to ten. In June, the AMN distribution comprised ten counties in Phase 5, 38 in Phase 4, 20 in Phase 3 and 11 in Phase 2. Because AMN Phase 5 also triggers a Band A floor under the 2026 framework, this change affected both the raw evidence contribution and the operation of the automatic restriction stage.

Disease pressure was High or Very High in about nine in ten counties across the period and added a small positive contribution to the national change. The relatively small contribution should not be read as low disease severity. It reflects the change between the first and final cycles, not the absolute level of pressure. A pillar can remain broadly severe while contributing little to the direction of the national trend if its classification changes only modestly.

What moved the national score



Pillar contributions and classification stages, which reconcile to the total change of +0.35 NSS points. Contributions are net effects between the first and last cycles and are rounded for presentation; the reconciliation checks use unrounded values.

The share of counties with High or Very High protection pressure decreased from about 75% to 57%, while High or Very High displacement-flow pressure fell from approximately 18% to 3%. These changes offset part of the increase generated by food insecurity, malnutrition and climate. They should be interpreted as lower measured contributions within the available evidence, not as proof that protection concerns or displacement ceased to matter.

High or Very High conflict pressure varied between roughly 38% and 49% of counties and made a modest negative contribution between January and June. Climate added about +0.11 points to the national mean over the period. These cycle-updated pillars help explain the smaller movements after March.